INLG 2026

The 19th International Natural Language Generation Conference

Proceedings of the Conference (Short Papers)

October 17-21, 2026

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Preface

We are excited to present the Proceedings of the 19th International Natural Language Generation Conference (INLG 2026). This year's INLG takes place from October 17 to October 21, 2026 in Utrecht, the Netherlands, and is organized by Utrecht University.

Conference details

The INLG conference is the main international forum for the presentation and discussion of research on Natural Language Generation (NLG). This year, we received 171 conference submissions (including 17 from ARR) and 5 demo paper submissions. After a peer review process, 80 long papers, 13 short papers, and 5 demo papers were accepted to the conference and are included in these proceedings.

The accepted papers showcase the breadth of NLG research, including work on applications, such as data-to-text tasks, machine translation, and summarization; language model evaluation; and many other topics of interest to the NLG community. We thank Rudali Huidrom for serving as Publication Chair and preparing these Proceedings.

Keynotes

We are also excited to have four keynote speakers contributing to this year's program. They will talk about distorted practices within current NLP research culture, language games as tools to evaluate language models' capabilities and for teaching, variation in human judgments and the role of explanations (both by humans and language models), and the complexity of sociotechnical generative systems. The keynote speakers are:

- Ehud Reiter, University of Aberdeen, Lifetime Achievement Keynote
- Malvina Nissim, University of Groningen
- Marie-Catherine de Marneffe, FNRS – UCLouvain
- Seraphina Goldfarb-Tarrant, Cohere

Generation Challenge

In continuation of a long tradition that goes back to 2007, INLG is hosting a Generation Challenge, a track of the main conference focused on developing shared tasks for NLG. The track is chaired by Simon Mille and Saad Mahamood and is described in its own proceedings volume.

Workshops

Four workshops are co-located with the main conference:

- Alternative Architectures and Generative Paradigms for NLG.
- The 2nd Workshop for Young Researchers in Natural Language Generation (YNLG).
- Workshop for Industrial NLP: NLP Research Towards Safety, Reliability, and Real-World Impact
- The 4th Workshop of AI Werewolf and Dialog System 2026 (AIWolfDial2026)

Tutorial

The program also offers a tutorial, titled *Beyond Leaderboards: Evaluation Practices for Open-Ended and Perspectival NLG*. This tutorial provides a practical, hands-on guide to evaluating open-ended NLG by introducing a five-layer design stack that helps researchers move beyond simple leaderboards to responsibly handle subjectivity and annotator disagreement. Presenters are Christina Niklaus (University of St.Gallen), Thomas Huber (University of St.Gallen).

A reflection on the state of INLG

Like all conferences in our field, we have had to deal with a major increase in submissions this year (see Table 1 below). Generally speaking, this is good news, a growing number of people is interested in natural language generation! At the same time, it is also a risk to our community, next to the increased pressure on the reviewing process, (over)burdening our reviewers, growing too quickly might also result in a loss of tradition and identity of our conference.

Year	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Submissions	102	147	119	76	51	98	96	122	176

Table 1: Direct submissions to INLG, excluding submissions via ACL's Rolling Review system.

What is INLG about?

For a long time, INLG has been a venue where researchers from academia and industry meet to discuss the development and deployment of NLG systems and the challenges that arise from this. The conference was always known for its strong emphasis on (human) evaluation and for its continued embrace of rule-based systems. In real-world settings, these are surprisingly hard to beat for their robustness. The conference has also focused on cognitive aspects, for instance, on gaining a deeper understanding of the differences and similarities between human and automatic language generation—a classic example is the generation of referring expressions.

The future of INLG

What does the future hold for INLG? We can imagine the possible nature of future editions as being on a spectrum from "focused on classical NLG" to "just another NLP conference." Once we as a community have determined where on that spectrum we would like to be, we can also think about ways to arrive at our preferred destination. For example, future editions of INLG could have:

- A narrower scope accepting papers on fewer specific topics (potentially changing with each edition).
- More detailed reviewer instructions, for instance, papers must include human-based studies.
- Tutorials and hackathons on bringing aspects of rule-based systems into current LLM-based architectures.

But these decisions are really up to the SIGGEN community. We are looking forward to discussing this topic at the conference.

Your INLG 2026 program chairs,
Guanyi Chen, Laura Perez-Beltrachini, and Emiel van Miltenburg

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